SLIDE PACK

Module D: Network intrusion analysis

3 units, 67 slides.



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Unit U06

CREST Practitioner Intrusion Analyst (CPIA)

Network Intrusion Analysis I: Capture, Logs & Network Config

Collecting the traffic, reading the logs, and spotting the misconfigurations that let attackers in.

GROUP D | CAPTURE | LOGS | CONFIG



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Three units on network intrusion analysis

unit	Focus	Skill areas
6	Capture, logs & network config	D1 Capture, D2 Log Sources, D3 Config Issues
7	C2, exfiltration & incoming attacks	D6 Encryption, D7 C2, D8 Exfiltration, D9 Incoming Attacks
8	Recon, spread & false positives	D10 Recon, D11 Internal Spread & Privilege Escalation, D13 False Positives

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UNIT OBJECTIVES

By the end of this unit you will be able to

- **Collect network traffic** with packet analysers, sniffing tools and switches or routers
- **Design a collection system** so enough data is captured without overwhelming devices
- **Explain SPAN ports and TAPs** including aggregating TAPs and fibre access
- **Estimate capture requirements** and choose deployment locations during scoping
- **Identify data and log sources** proxy, syslog, firewall, DHCP, DNS, VPN, web, email and more
- **Spot network configuration issues** routing, DNS leakage, firewall evasion

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Methods of data collection

- **What we collect** packets of data on the network, carrying source and destination information
- **Tools** packet analysers, sniffing tools, switches and routers
- **Why we collect** intrusions, performance, quality of service (QoS)
- **The goal** enough data to reconstruct the incident without overwhelming the capture device

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Capture tools

Tool	Type	Notes
Wireshark	GUI packet analyser	Live capture or historical .pcap; filtering; automatic protocol analysis
tshark	Terminal interface	The command-line version of Wireshark
tcpdump	Terminal based	Limited in what it can decode
Netsniff-ng	Terminal based	High-performance Linux capture
zANTI	Android based	Network analysis and man-in-the-middle testing; wireless capture
SwitchProbe	Fibre monitoring	Monitor, map, report; can be configured to capture

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Filtering captured traffic

- **Reduce network impact** filtering lowers the load on the network
- **Reduce the data to analyse** only the relevant traffic is kept
- **Work within storage limits** the capture device's storage is finite
- **Typically at analysis stage** filtering is usually performed when analysing
- **Filter by** protocol, source and destination

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Impact of traffic capture

- **Bridge capture?** is it necessary to place a device between the target and the network?
- **Transparency** can the capture device be made transparent to the traffic?
- **Attacker awareness** will the attacker be alerted to the sniffing?
- **Design the system** so that capture does not alter the very behaviour we are observing

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SPAN ports and network TAPs

Method	How it works	Notes
SPAN port	Switched Port ANalyzer — mirrors data on one port to another	Switch-device based
Network TAP	Traffic Analysis Point — snoops on traffic in the network	Requires no external power source
Aggregating TAP	Combines multiple streams into one	Can allow access to fibre-optic networks

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Scope of the analysis

- **Focus on data required** and on the suspect machines
- **Only capture what is needed** avoid drowning the analysis in noise
- **Identify** ports in use, network topology, security devices
- **Find available logs** that can assist the investigation
- **Deployment location** use network diagrams and the scope to focus the capture

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Capture options

Option	Description
NetFlow	Only IP traffic; requires four components — exporter, collector, storage and analysis console
Limited capture	Capture only the traffic that fits the scope
Full packet capture	Capture everything — most data, most storage

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Preserving network security and integrity

- **Encrypt captured files** protect the data at rest
- **Secure the capture device** physical and logical protection
- **Limit access to TAPs** only authorised personnel
- **Remove SPAN ports after use** leave the network as it was found
- **Assure integrity** arguments and evidence that the captured data is sound

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Data sources and network log sources

- **Identification is challenging** every network differs from another
- **Intruders leave a trace** the logs capture it if they are present and retained
- **Types of data source** routers, switches, servers, computers, IDS, databases
- **Use the data** to reconstruct the incident timeline

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Log source checklist

Log type	Key information
Proxy	Timestamps, IPs, URLs, bandwidth usage, proxy action
syslog	Timestamps, IPs, severity levels, descriptive messages
Email	Timestamps, server and client IPs, sender and recipient, delivery status, error codes
Firewall	Network activities, threats, timestamps, IPs, ports, protocols
DHCP	Assigned IPs, client hostnames, MAC addresses, event descriptions
VPN	External access, timestamps, external and internal IPs, ports, protocols, usernames
Web server	Visitor IPs, device types, OS and browser versions, requested files
Antivirus	Last scan, signature updates, found malware, actions taken
DNS	Queries, source and destination IPs, ports, statuses
Database	Who accessed, when, and what transactions or modifications were made

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Syslog and Windows event logs

- **Syslog** a method of logging messages about a system; records timestamps, IPs, severity and descriptive messages
- **Syslog server** receives syslogs from network devices, listens and collects — assists the investigator
- **Windows event logs** locally stored logs on each host
- **Three well-known logs** Application, System and Security
- **Domain logs** record user logins, machines, units, password changes and accessed resources

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Questions to ask of any data source

- **How long is the data stored?** retention windows vary by source
- **Is it overwritten after a period?** older data may be gone
- **Is it stored securely?** could it have been tampered with?
- **How will we handle volume?** excessive data needs a plan
- **Correlate across sources** the complete picture comes from joining many logs

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Network configuration security issues

Issue	Examples
IP routing issues	IP address spoofing, source routing
DNS information leakage	DNS spoofing, DNS cache poisoning
Unexpected traffic routes	man-in-the-middle via ARP poisoning or DNS spoofing
Email routing issues	misconfigured BIND, named log anomalies
Firewalls / rules not working	SMB, NetBIOS, tftp, RPC, rlogin, rsh, rexec exposed
Redundant firewall rules	stale rules weaken the security posture

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Detecting man-in-the-middle

- **ARP poisoning** an attacker's MAC replaces the gateway's in the ARP table
- **Test with arp -a** compare the gateway MAC against the known-good value
- **DNS spoofing** a poisoned DNS response sends traffic to the attacker
- **Test with DNS lookups** verify the resolved address matches the legitimate one
- **Compare before and after** a changed gateway MAC is a red flag

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Detecting firewall and proxy evasion

- **IP address spoofing** forging the source address to bypass filters
- **Source routing** forcing traffic along an unexpected path
- **Fragmentation** splitting packets so rules miss the payload
- **IP addresses to access websites** bypassing name-based proxy controls
- **Tunnelling** ICMP tunnelling, ACK tunnelling, HTTP tunnelling

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DISCUSSION

Why must a capture device be made transparent to the traffic, and what could alert an attacker if it is not?

Consider what happens if the device changes timing, drops packets, or is placed as a visible bridge in the path.

A transparent device captures without altering the behaviour it is observing.

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CONSOLIDATION · D1–D3

Network intrusion analysis I at a glance

Ref	Topic	Core idea
D1	Network traffic capture	Wireshark, tshark, tcpdump, SPAN ports, TAPs, capture options
D2	Data & log sources	Proxy, syslog, firewall, DHCP, DNS, VPN, web, email, antivirus, event logs
D3	Network config issues	Routing, DNS leakage, firewall evasion, man-in-the-middle

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Capture is a design decision** scope, filter and place devices so you collect enough without overwhelming
- **SPAN vs TAP** SPAN mirrors a port; TAPs and aggregating TAPs snoop without external power
- **Logs tell the story** proxy, firewall, DNS, DHCP, VPN, syslog and event logs must be correlated
- **Config flaws are findings** routing, DNS leakage and redundant rules weaken the network
- **Evasion is deliberate** spoofing, fragmentation and tunnelling bypass firewall and proxy rules
- **Protect the evidence** encrypt captures, secure the device, remove SPAN ports after use

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QUIZ

confirmation quiz (D1–D3)

- Which Wireshark tool is its terminal interface?
- What does a SPAN port do?
- Which log records the IP addresses assigned to hosts?
- What does a changed gateway MAC in arp -a suggest?
- Which technique tunnels data inside ICMP to evade a firewall?

Answers in the confirmation quiz — aim for 60 percent before leaving.

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NEXT SESSION

Next unit: Network Intrusion Analysis II

- Encryption — flow analysis, fingerprinting, weak obfuscation (XOR, ROL, codebooks)
- Command and control channels — botnets, centralised vs distributed C2
- Exfiltration of data — covert channels, behavioural analysis, watermarking
- Incoming attacks — DoS, IDS/IPS, email attacks and signature vs statistical detection

Reading: Knowledge Group D source material.

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Unit U07

CREST Practitioner Intrusion Analyst (CPIA)

Network Intrusion Analysis II: C2, Exfiltration & Incoming Attacks

Encryption and flow analysis, command-and-control, data exfiltration, and detecting the attacks coming in.

GROUP D | ENCRYPTION | C2 | EXFILTRATION | ATTACKS



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This unit: D6–D9

Ref	Skill area	Focus
D6	Encryption	Flow analysis, fingerprinting, weak obfuscation
D7	Command and Control Channels	Botnets, C2 architectures, detection
D8	Exfiltration of Data	Covert and open exfiltration, behavioural analysis
D9	Incoming Attacks	DoS, IDS/IPS, signature and statistical detection

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UNIT OBJECTIVES

By the end of this unit you will be able to

- **Analyse traffic flows** volume, direction, QoS, timing, custom or standard encryption
- **Understand channel fingerprinting** one source, many destinations, increasing ports, SYN flags
- **Identify weak obfuscation** XOR, ROL, codebooks — and approaches to deobfuscation
- **Detect command-and-control** covert and open C2 via statistics, signatures and manual review
- **Recognise data exfiltration** covert channels, behavioural analysis, watermarking, prevention
- **Detect incoming attacks** DoS, signature and statistical systems, email attacks

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Analysis of traffic flows

- **Flows** sequences of related packets examined for patterns
- **Flow analysis** identify traffic patterns, isolate suspicious activity, analyse higher-layer protocols, extract data
- **Flow definitions** quality of service (QoS), volume, directionality
- **Follow TCP stream** reassemble a conversation in Wireshark
- **Flow tools** tcpflow, pcapcat, tcpxtract for reconstruction and carving

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Flow analysis techniques

1. **List conversations and flows**
   get an overview of who talked to whom
2. **Export a flow**
   extract the conversation of interest
3. **File and data carving**
   recover files and data from the stream
4. **Active pattern matching**
   IPs, ports, protocols and flags, directionality, volume

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Fingerprinting

- **Channel fingerprinting** a pattern that identifies a remote channel or tool
- **One source IP address** a single host beaconing out
- **One or more destination IPs** many targets from one source
- **Increasing destination ports** ports climbing incrementally
- **Volume of packets** unusual packet counts
- **SYN flags outbound** a TCP protocol signature of scanning or probing

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Weak obfuscation and deobfuscation

Scheme	Description
XOR	Byte-wise exclusive-or with a key; reversible with the same key
ADD / SUB	Arithmetic on bytes; used in tandem since they are not reversible alone
ROL / ROR	Circular bit rotations; used together as they are not reversible
ROT	Caesar cipher over A–Z or the 94 printable ASCII characters
Multibyte	Longer keys, often 4 or 8 bytes, typically XOR per block
Chained / loopback	Encoded output becomes the key for the next character

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Deobfuscation

- **Deobfuscation** making sense of something that has been encoded
- **XOR** apply the same key again to recover the plaintext
- **BASE64** a common encoding layer to strip before analysis
- **Codebooks** lookup tables replacing data with codes
- **The goal** reduce weak obfuscation to readable content for the investigation

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Botnets and command-and-control

- **Botnet** a large network of compromised computers, infected with malicious code and remotely controlled by one or more cybercriminals
- **C&C servers** the command-and-control infrastructure
- **Types** centralised, distributed, and hybrid C&C
- **Uses** spam distribution, DDoS, identity theft, online advertising fraud

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C2 architectures compared

Type	Advantages	Weakness
Centralised	Low reaction time, good coordination power, easy monitoring	Single point of failure
Distributed	High anonymity for botmasters, difficult to disarticulate, more robust	More complex to manage
Hybrid	Combines centralised control with distributed bot groups	Servant bots and client bots add complexity

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Botnet lifecycle and detection

- **Lifecycle** conception, recruitment, connection, marketing, execution, maintenance
- **Signature-based detection** IDS/IPS detection of known botnets
- **Anomaly-based detection** high latency, unusual ports, unusual system behaviour
- **DNS-based detection** analysis of DNS traffic for bot-related names
- **Review traffic and logs** IDS, IPS, web server access.log and error.log

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Data exfiltration

- **Manual** by an individual with physical access to a computer
- **Automated** through malicious programming over a network
- **Access points** the many ways data leaves the network
- **Attack paths** obtained passwords, remote access, APTs — advanced persistent threats
- **FTP misconfiguration** misconfigured servers, default passwords, plaintext credentials

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Exfiltration vectors

- **Web applications** an attacker uses their own browser to access data directly — ordinary, hard to suspect
- **WMI** Windows Management Instrumentation used to move data
- **Covert channels** VOIP tunnels, ICMP tunnels, DNS tunnels, HTTP tunnels
- **Encrypted transport** all of these protocols can carry encrypted data out of the network

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Behavioural analysis and prevention

- **Behavioural analysis** automatically detect destinations that receive far more uploaded data than typical
- **Relevant fields** bytes sent, client host/IP, destination host/IP (e.g. in proxy logs)
- **Watermarking** an overt detection technique — track files and monitor what happens to them
- **Prevention** secure endpoints, stronger IT controls, physical and logical security, DLP, inspection of traffic

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Public-facing services under attack

- **Public-facing services** web servers, FTP servers, mail servers — accessible via the internet
- **Constant threat** a steady stream of approaches against these services
- **Impact** interruption and destruction
- **Detect via** manual review of traffic, system performance, firewall and web server logs

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Detecting denial of service

- **High volume of incoming traffic** a classic DoS signature
- **Single or multiple source IPs** attackers may come from one or many addresses
- **Protocol abuse** malformed handshakes, large ping packets
- **SYN flood** an incomplete three-way handshake saturates the server
- **System performance** excessive CPU and memory usage indicates an attack

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Signature vs statistical detection

System	How it works	Limitations
Statistical	Detects abnormal behaviour	Requires extensive configuration; false positives easy; malicious traffic may go unnoticed
Signature	Detects known malicious activity from a signature database	Must be constantly updated; only as good as its database
IDS / IPS	Combine statistical and signature approaches	Network-based (NIDS) or host-based (HIDS); e.g. Snort

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Email attacks

- **Problematic** for both individuals and organisations
- **Range** malicious attachments, mail bombing, phishing emails
- **Detect attachments** with email malware scanners
- **Detect mail bombing** the usual signs of DoS plus an increase in inbox storage
- **Manual phishing detection** scrutinise the email for tell-tale signs

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DISCUSSION

Why is detecting a covert C2 channel harder than detecting a centralised one, and which indicators help?

Think about anonymity, the lack of a single server, and what anomalies remain visible in traffic.

Distributed and covert C2 are harder to pin down; anomalies, DNS and volume analysis still help.

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CONSOLIDATION · D6–D9

Network intrusion analysis II at a glance

Ref	Topic	Core idea
D6	Encryption	Flow analysis, fingerprinting, XOR/ROL/codebook deobfuscation
D7	Command and control	Botnets, centralised/distributed/hybrid C2, detection
D8	Exfiltration	Covert channels, behavioural analysis, watermarking, DLP
D9	Incoming attacks	DoS, signature vs statistical detection, email attacks

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Flows are the unit of analysis** follow TCP streams, list conversations, carve files
- **Fingerprint the channel** one source, many destinations, rising ports, SYN flags
- **Weak obfuscation is reversible** XOR, ROL, codebooks and BASE64 can be deobfuscated
- **C2 comes in three flavours** centralised, distributed and hybrid — each with strengths and weaknesses
- **Exfiltration hides in plain sight** covert tunnels, web apps, WMI; detect by volume and watermark
- **Detect by signature and statistics** IDS/IPS plus manual review of traffic and logs

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QUIZ

confirmation quiz (D6–D9)

- Which command reassembles a TCP conversation in Wireshark?
- Which obfuscation scheme uses a Caesar shift over characters?
- Which C2 architecture has a single point of failure?
- Which detection technique tracks watermarked files?
- What is a SYN flood?
- Which detection approach needs constant signature updates?

Answers in the confirmation quiz — aim for 60 percent before leaving.

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NEXT SESSION

Next unit: Network Intrusion Analysis III

- Reconnaissance — how attackers map the network before acting
- Internal spread and privilege escalation — vertical and horizontal
- Windows event IDs, command history and scheduled tasks
- False positive acknowledgement — interpreting results honestly

Reading: Knowledge Group D source material.

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Unit U08

CREST Practitioner Intrusion Analyst (CPIA)

Network Intrusion Analysis III: Recon, Internal Spread & False Positives

Mapping the network, moving through it, escalating privilege, and acknowledging what the evidence really shows.

GROUP D | RECONNAISSANCE | PRIVILEGE ESCALATION | FALSE POSITIVES

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WELCOME · KNOWLEDGE GROUP D

This unit: D10, D11, D13

Ref	Skill area	Focus
D10	Reconnaissance	How attackers map the network before acting
D11	Internal Spread & Privilege Escalation	Vertical and horizontal escalation, spread, artefacts
D13	False Positive Acknowledgement	Interpreting results honestly and corroborating

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UNIT OBJECTIVES

By the end of this unit you will be able to

- **Detect reconnaissance** the probing that maps the network before an attack
- **Detect internal spread** malware moving laterally across the network
- **Recognise privilege escalation** vertical and horizontal, and how to test for it
- **Identify escalation artefacts** audit logs, event IDs, command history, scheduled tasks
- **Acknowledge false positives** corroborate results and interpret evidence honestly

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Reconnaissance in the kill chain

- **The first kill-chain phase** research, identify and select targets
- **External recon** WHOIS, DNS, OSINT — everything from Unit U5
- **Internal recon** after compromise, the attacker maps the environment
- **Purpose** learn the network, find targets, plan the next move
- **Detect the pattern** scans, probes, unusual lookups, enumeration traffic

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Indicators of reconnaissance

- **Scanning and probing** many connections, rising ports, SYN patterns
- **Enumeration** banner grabbing, service identification
- **DNS and WHOIS queries** bulk lookups before an attack
- **Credential probing** repeated login attempts
- **Correlate with logs** firewall, IDS and web logs reveal the pattern

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Privilege escalation: vertical and horizontal

Type	Meaning	Example
Vertical	Gaining higher privileges than intended	A standard user escalating to administrator or root
Horizontal	Gaining the privileges of another user at the same level	User A accessing User B's bank account
Permission creep	Accumulated privileges beyond those required	Users keep old rights when roles change

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How privileges are escalated

- **Vertical methods** user impersonation, Linux kernel manipulation, cross-zone scripting, shell injection, jailbreaking and rooting
- **Exploit common weaknesses** theft or hijacking of unit cookies, predictable unit IDs, unit fixation, cross-site scripting
- **Weak credentials** easily guessable passwords
- **Keystroke logging** capturing credentials as they are typed
- **The result** an attacker with more privilege than they should hold

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Testing for privilege escalation

- **Vertical testing** try to reach a higher privilege level than intended
- **Horizontal testing** attempt to access another user's account or data
- **unit weaknesses** predictable unit IDs, unit fixation, cookie theft
- **Web application flaws** cross-site scripting and access-control failures
- **Weak credentials** guessable passwords and keystroke logging

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The compromise: from initial access to sensitive data

1. **Initial compromise**
   the attacker gains a foothold
2. **Internal reconnaissance**
   obtain and learn about the environment
3. **Seek additional targets**
   find other systems to move to
4. **Escalate and move**
   raise privileges and move around the network
5. **Gain access to sensitive resources**
   the attacker reaches their objective

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Investigating escalation: audit logs

- **Audit logs** Windows security logs, auth log, secure log
- **What to look for** valid and invalid log-on attempts, newly created or modified user accounts
- **Command execution history** ipconfig, ifconfig, tasklist, ps, traceroute, netstat
- **Task scheduler and registry** scheduled tasks and registry entries
- **Network traffic** review recent and active connections

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Windows event IDs to know

Event ID	Meaning
4624	Successful login
4625	Failed login
4768	Kerberos authentication (ticket granting)
4769	Kerberos service ticket
4776	NTLM authentication
4672	Assignment of administrator rights
106 / 140 / 141	Scheduled task registered / updated / removed

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Command history across platforms

Purpose	Windows	Unix
Network config	ipconfig	ifconfig
Connections	netstat	netstat
Route trace	tracert	traceroute
Processes	tasklist	ps
System info	systeminfo	uname
Identity	whoami	whoami / id / sudo -l
List files	dir	ls
View files	type	cat

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Scheduled tasks and registry

- **Scheduled tasks** the use of 'at' or 'schtasks' to run code
- **Gain SYSTEM privileges** tasks can run at high privilege
- **Run code under a compromised account** persistence and execution
- **Registry keys** can be modified easily — poor configuration leaves a system vulnerable
- **Detect via event IDs** 106 registered, 140 updated, 141 removed

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Detecting malware spread within the network

- **Review recent and active connections** current state of the network
- **Manual review of traffic and logs** identify what is abnormal
- **Review abnormal connections** unexpected destinations and protocols
- **Correlate across hosts** the same infection on many systems indicates spread

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False positive acknowledgement

- **The risk** automated tools flag many benign items as malicious
- **False dependence** over-reliance on a single commercial tool
- **Acknowledge honestly** state clearly what is a true positive and what is not
- **Corroborate** use multiple vendors' data and analyse the results yourself
- **The professional standard** conclusions must be defensible and reproducible

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Turning an alert into a finding

1. **Receive an alert**
   from IDS, antivirus, or a manual review
2. **Validate the indicator**
   is the signature or anomaly genuine?
3. **Corroborate across sources**
   traffic, logs, multiple vendors, manual analysis
4. **Acknowledge the outcome**
   true positive or false positive, stated clearly
5. **Document and report**
   a defensible, evidence-backed conclusion

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DISCUSSION

Why is acknowledging a false positive as important as confirming a true positive in a report?

Consider credibility, the cost of chasing phantom alerts, and how the client judges the analyst's work.

Honest acknowledgement builds trust and keeps investigations focused on genuine threats.

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CONSOLIDATION · D10–D13

Network intrusion analysis III at a glance

Ref	Topic	Core idea
D10	Reconnaissance	Map the network before acting — scans, probes, enumeration
D11	Internal spread & escalation	Vertical and horizontal escalation; event IDs, command history, scheduled tasks
D13	False positives	Acknowledge honestly, corroborate, make defensible conclusions

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Recon precedes attack** both externally and internally, the attacker maps before moving
- **Escalation is vertical or horizontal** higher privilege, or another user's privilege
- **Artefacts reveal the move** event IDs 4624/4625/4768/4672, command history, scheduled tasks
- **Spread shows in correlation** the same infection across hosts indicates lateral movement
- **False positives are normal** acknowledge, corroborate, and never over-claim
- **Conclusions must be defensible** multi-source, reproducible and honestly reported

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QUIZ

confirmation quiz (D10–D13)

- Which kill-chain phase precedes weaponisation?
- What does Event ID 4625 indicate?
- What is horizontal privilege escalation?
- Which Windows command shows network configuration?
- How should an analyst handle a possible false positive?
- What does Event ID 106 indicate?

Answers in the confirmation quiz — aim for 60 percent before leaving.

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NEXT SESSION

Next unit: Analysing Host Intrusions I

- Acquisition and live analysis lab setup
- The acquisition of evidence and forensic imaging
- Setting up an analysis environment
- Introduction to host-level intrusion analysis

Reading: Knowledge Group E source material.

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